

These lily lips,
 This cherry nose,
 These yellow cowslip cheeks,
 Are gone, are gone:
 Lovers, make moan:
 His eyes were green as leeks.
 O Sisters Three,
 Come, come to me,
 With hands as pale as milk;
 Lay them in gore,
 Since you have shore
 With shears his thread of silk.
 Tongue, not a word:
 Come, trusty sword;
 Come, blade, my breast imbrue:

(Stabs herself.)

And, farewell, friends;
 Thus Thisby ends:
 Adieu, adieu, adieu.

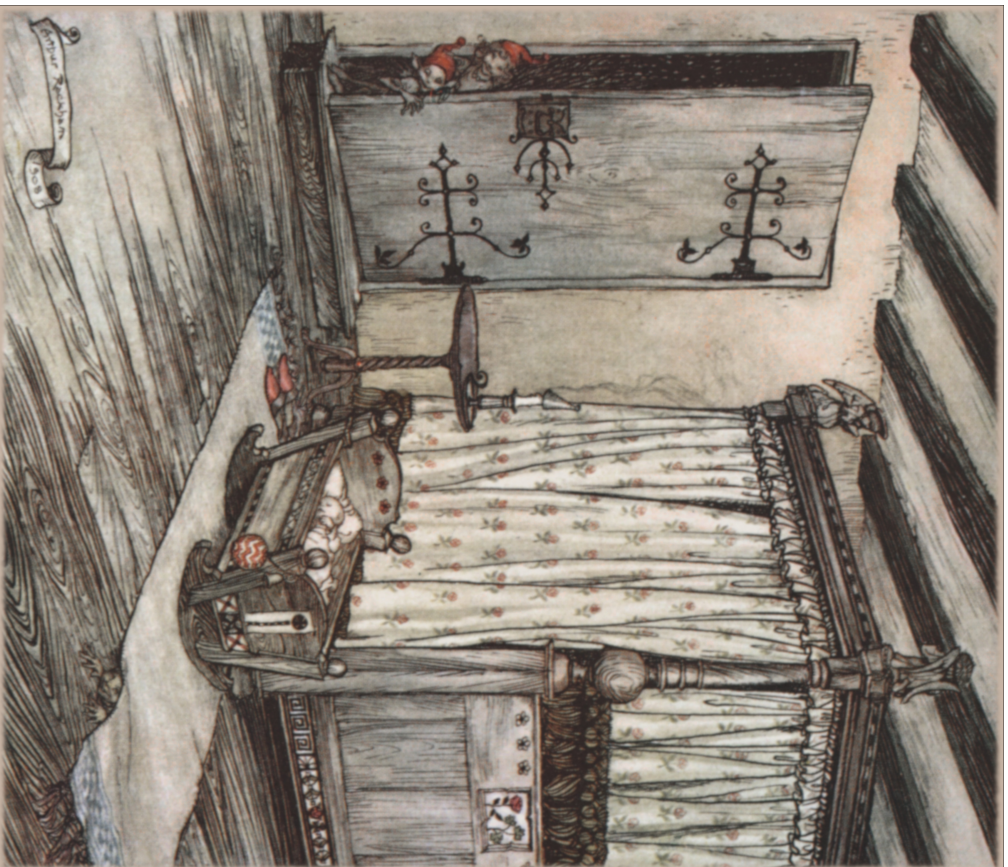
(Dies.)

THESEUS
 Moonshine and Lion are left to bury the dead.

DEMETRIUS
 Ay, and Wall too.

BOTTOM

(Starting up)
 No assure you; the wall is down that parted their fathers. Will it please you to see the epilogue, or to hear a Bergomask dance between two of our company?



'LOVERS, TO BED; 'TIS ALMOST FAIRY TIME'

THESEUS

No epilogue, I pray you; for your play needs no excuse. Never excuse; for when the players are all dead, there needs none to be blamed. Marry, if he that writ it had played Pyramus and hanged himself in Thisbe's garter, it would have been a fine tragedy: and so it is, truly; and very notably discharged. But come, your Bergomask: let your epilogue alone.

(A dance, and the players exit.)

The iron tongue of midnight hath told twelve:
Lovers, to bed; 'tis almost fairy time.

I fear we shall out-sleep the coming morn
As much as we this night have overwatch'd.

This palpable-gross play hath well beguiled
The heavy gait of night. Sweet friends, to bed.

A fortnight hold we this solemnity,
In nightly revels and new jollity.

(Exeunt omnes.)

(Enter PUCK.)

PUCK

Now the hungry lion roars,
And the wolf behowls the moon;
Whilst the heavy ploughman snores,
All with weary task fordone.

Now the wasted brands do glow,
Whilst the screech-owl, screeching loud,
Puts the wretch that lies in woe
In remembrance of a shroud.

Now it is the time of night
That the graves all gaping wide,
Every one lets forth his sprite,
In the church-way paths to glide:
And we fairies, that do run
By the triple Hecate's team,
From the presence of the sun,
Following darkness like a dream,

DEMETRIUS

No die, but an ace, for him; for he is but one.

LYSANDER

Less than an ace, man; for he is dead; he is nothing.

THESEUS

With the help of a surgeon he might yet recover, and prove an ass.

HIPPOLYTA

How chance Moonshine is gone before Thisbe comes back and
finds her lover?

THESEUS

She will find him by starlight. Here she comes; and her passion ends
the play.

(Re-enter THISBE.)

HIPPOLYTA

Methinks she should not use a long one for such a Pyramus: I hope
she will be brief.

DEMETRIUS

A mote will turn the balance, which Pyramus, which Thisbe, is the
better; he for a man, God warrant us; she for a woman, God bless us.

LYSANDER

She hath spied him already with those sweet eyes.

DEMETRIUS

And thus she means, videlicet:—

THISBE

Asleep, my love?
What, dead, my dove?
O Pyramus, arise!
Speak, speak. Quite dumb?
Dead, dead? A tomb
Must cover thy sweet eyes.

Approach, ye Furies fell!

O Fates, come, come,

Cut thread and thrum;

Quail, crush, conclude, and quell!

THESEUS

This passion, and the death of a dear friend, would go near to make
a man look sad.

HIPPOLYTA

Beshrew my heart, but I pity the man.

PYRAMUS

O wherefore, Nature, didst thou lions frame?

Since lion vile hath here deflower'd my dear:

Which is—no, no—which was the fairest dame

That lived, that loved, that liked, that look'd with cheer.

Come, tears, confound;

Out, sword, and wound

The pap of Pyramus;

Ay, that left pap,

Where heart doth hop:

(Stabs himself.)

Thus die I, thus, thus, thus.

Now am I dead,

Now am I fled;

My soul is in the sky:

Tongue, lose thy light;

Moon take thy flight:

(Exit MOONSHINE.)

Now die, die, die, die, die.

(Dies.)



Now are frolic: not a mouse

Shall disturb this hallow'd house:

I am sent with broom before,

To sweep the dust behind the door.

(Enter OBERON and TITANIA with their train)

OBERON

Through the house give gathering light,

By the dead and drowsy fire:

Every elf and fairy sprite

Hop as light as bird from brier;

And this ditty, after me,

Sing, and dance it trippingly.

LION

(Roaring)

O!

(THISBE runs off.)

DEMETRIUS

Well roared, Lion.

THESEUS

Well run, Thisbe.

HIPPOLYTA

Well shone, Moon. Truly, the moon shines with a good grace.

(The LION shakes THISBE's mantle, and exits.)

THESEUS

Well moused, Lion.

LYSANDER

And so the lion vanished.

DEMETRIUS

And then came Pyramus.

(Enter PYRAMUS.)

PYRAMUS

Sweet Moon, I thank thee for thy sunny beams;

I thank thee, Moon, for shining now so bright;

For, by thy gracious, golden, glittering gleams,

I trust to take of truest Thisby sight.

But stray, O spite!

But mark, poor knight,

What dreadful dole is here!

Eyes, do you see?

How can it be?

O dainty duck! O dear!

Thy mantle good,

What, stain'd with blood!

THROUGH THE HOUSE GIVE GATHERING LIGHT





Exit Moonshine.

TITANIA

First, rehearse your song by rote
To each word a warbling note:
Hand in hand, with fairy grace,
Will we sing, and bless this place.

(Song and dance.)

OBERON

Now, until the break of day,
Through this house each fairy stray.
To the best bride-bed will we,
Which by us shall blessed be;
And the issue there create
Ever shall be fortunate.
So shall all the couples three
Ever true in loving be;
And the blots of Nature's hand
Shall not in their issue stand;
Never mole, hare lip, nor scar,
Nor mark prodigious, such as are
Despised in nativity,
Shall upon their children be.
With this field-dew consecrate,
Every fairy take his gait;
And each several chamber bless,
Through this palace, with sweet peace;
And the owner of it blest
Ever shall in safety rest.
Trip away; make no stay;
Meet me all by break of day.

(Exit OBERON, TITANIA and TRAIN.)

PUCK

If we shadows have offended,
Think but this, and all is mended,
That you have but slumber'd here

MOONSHINE

All that I have to say, is, to tell you that the lantern is the moon; I, the man in the moon; this thorn-bush, my thorn-bush; and this dog, my dog.

DEMETRIUS

Why, all these should be in the lantern, for all these are in the moon. But, silence! here comes Thisbe.

(Enter THISBE.)

THISBE

This is old Nimmy's tomb. Where is my love?

While these visions did appear.
And this weak and idle theme,
No more yielding but a dream,
Gentles, do not reprehend:
if you pardon, we will mend:
And, as I am an honest Puck,
If we have unearned luck
Now to 'scape the serpent's tongue,
We will make amends ere long;
Else the Puck a liar call;
So, good night unto you all.
Give me your hands, if we be friends,
And Robin shall restore amends.

(Exeunt omnes.)

DEMETRIUS
Not so, my lord; for his valour cannot carry his discretion; and the
fox carries the goose.

THESEUS
His discretion, I am sure, cannot carry his valour; for the goose
carries not the fox. It is well: leave it to his discretion, and let us
listen to the moon.

MOONSHINE
This lanthorn doth the hornèd moon present;—

DEMETRIUS
He should have worn the horns on his head.

THESEUS
He is no crescent, and his horns are invisible within the
circumference.

MOONSHINE
This lanthorn doth the hornèd moon present;
Myself the man i' the moon do seem to be.

THESEUS
This is the greatest error of all the rest: the man should be put into
the lanthorn. How is it else 'the man i' the moon?'

DEMETRIUS
He dares not come there for the candle; for, you see, it is already in
snuff.

HIPPOLYTA
I am awear of this moon: would he would change!

THESEUS
It appears, by his small light of discretion, that he is in the wane; but
yet, in courtesy, in all reason, we must stay the time.

LYSANDER
Proceed, Moon.

A Midsummer Night's Dream

HIPPOLYTA

This is the silliest stuff that ever I heard.

THESEUS

The best in this kind are but shadows; and the worst are no worse, if imagination amend them.

HIPPOLYTA

It must be your imagination then, and not theirs.

THESEUS

If we imagine no worse of them than they of themselves, they may pass for excellent men. Here come two noble beasts in, a man and a lion.

(Enter LION and MOONSHINE.)

LION

You, ladies, you, whose gentle hearts do fear
The smallest monstrous mouse that creeps on floor,
May now perchance both quake and tremble here,
When lion rough in wildest rage doth roar.
Then know that I, one Snug the joiner, am
A lion-fell, nor else no lion's dam;
For, if I should as lion come in strife
Into this place, 'twere pity on my life.

THESEUS

A very gentle beast, of a good conscience.

DEMETRIUS

The very best at a beast, my lord, that e'er I saw.

LYSANDER

This lion is a very fox for his valour.

THESEUS

True; and a goose for his discretion.





A Midsummer Night's Dream was first performed in 1595 or 1596, after William Shakespeare (1564–1616) had written *Romeo and Juliet* and probably just before *The Merchant of Venice*. It was first published in 1600 (the ‘first quarto’ edition) by William Jaggard, in London (UK). Illustrations by British artist Arthur Rackham (1867–1939) are from a 1908 edition published by Heinemann in London (UK) and Doubleday in New York (US). Grateful acknowledgement is made to the Internet Archive, which in 2007 digitised a copy of this edition belonging to the New York Public Library. Additional illustrations are taken from various other Rackham works.

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THISBE
My love thou art, my love I think.

PYRAMUS
Think what thou wilt, I am thy lover’s grace;
And, like Limander, am I trusty still.

THISBE
And I like Helen, till the Fates me kill.

PYRAMUS
Not Shafalus to Procrus was so true.

THISBE
As Shafalus to Procrus, I to you.

PYRAMUS
O kiss me through the hole of this vile wall!

THISBE
I kiss the wall’s hole, not your lips at all.

PYRAMUS
Wilt thou at Ninny’s tomb meet me straightway?

THISBE
‘Tide life, ‘tide death, I come without delay.
(*Exeunt PYRAMUS and THISBE.*)

WALL
Thus have I, Wall, my part discharged so;
And, being done, thus Wall away doth go.
(*Exit WALL.*)

THESEUS
Now is the mural down between the two neighbours.

DEMETRIUS
No remedy, my lord, when walls are so wilful to hear without
warning.